

SATHYASHODHANA RANGA SAMUDAYA TRUST, HEGGODU (R).

A CULTURAL TRUST
JANAMANADATA DIVISION
A REPORT – 2019-20



A scene from Kurukshethra (Janamanadata 2019-20), Dir. by Dr. M. Ganesha

Introduction:

Sathyashodhana Ranga Samudaya, previously known as Janamanadata, is a cultural trust founded and registered in October 2015 and based at Heggodu, Sagara taluk, Shivamogga District, Karnataka. It grew out of the activities and initiatives of Janamanadata, a theatre group which came into existence in May 2005 and today includes Janamanadata as a division. The Trust, at one level, strives towards realising the ideals of liberty, equality, fraternity, and social justice. At another, practical, level, it aims at providing a platform for enhancing their theatre craft and art for young theatre activists. The group works under the leadership of Dr. M. Ganesha, a versatile and highly experienced theatre practitioner and teacher.

Sathyashodhana Ranga Samudaya has an impressive list of achievements to show so far. Between 2005 and 2019, through its arm Janamanadata, it put up 10 theatre productions covering a wide range of forms, styles, themes, source-languages like Shraddha mattu Hanate, Uchalya, Rahasya Vishwa, Tabarana Kathe, Babasaheb Ambedkar, Sooryana Kudure, Oorukeri, Baduku Bayalu, Sathyashodhaka, Odiri, and Kurukshethra. Of these, some were original Kannada plays, some Kannada translations of plays from different languages, and some adaptations of

literary works again from different languages. Some productions were specific to a particular season or year, while some were continued over more than one season/year owing to popular demand or their social relevance. Janamanadata's productions of Oorukeri, Baduku Bayalu, Sathyashodhaka, Babasaheb Ambedkar, and Kurukshethra have been hailed as landmark works in the history of Kannada theatre.

Up to the end of year 2019-20, the group has put up 707 performances in and outside Karnataka. The productions are designed in such a way that they can be performed in a wide variety of physical spaces differing from one another as regards stage area, structure, seating capacity, infrastructure, etc.

The Janamanadata theatre troupe began with 7 actors, and has 17 today. These perform all back-stage and off-stage work as well as on-stage work. They conduct all the activities before and during the performance-tour pooling together their own finances and at the end of the tour share the collections on an equal basis. A certain part of the income earned every season/year is utilised for purchase of essential theatre equipment.

In its fifteen years of existence, Janamanadata has visited all 31 districts of Karnataka. Though it has not performed in every district every year, it has performed in each geographical zone or revenue division every year.

JANAMANADATA: AN OVERVIEW

- A theatre group established in 2005; has grown from a band of 7 to 17 artistes now;
- These artistes handle all on-stage, backstage and off-stage work;
- They all share all the initial investment every season and also share all the earnings every season-end;
- 1 or 2 productions rehearsed over a month and tour shows held over a 2-to-3 month period every season;
- One show every 25-75 kms. of travel and a performance almost every day, which works out to about 45-55 shows over 60 days of tour;
- A total distance of 70800 kilometres covered so far on show-tours.
- 707 shows of 10 productions so far, to an estimated total audience of 6,11,590;
- 90% of the shows have been held in rural Karnataka, in taluka towns, hobali centres, villages and hamlets;
- Performed in all districts of Karnataka;
- Both local and invited directors from outside have worked on the productions, some of which have even taken form under collective direction from the entire group;
- The group has not applied for or received any State or Central Government grant thus far;
- It has sustained itself so far through investments made by the artistes themselves, donations from patrons, charges paid by show-hosting organisations;



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JANAMANADATA 2019-20

The group toured its production of Kurukshethra in April-May period of 2019. It repeated Kurukshethra this season first of all because of its great popularity and public demand.

Technical details of the production Kurukshethra are as follows:

KURUKSHETHRA

A theatre production based on a composite script incorporating sections from different individual plays written on the same episode by eminent Kannada writers B. Puttaswamayya and Kuvempu, productions based on the same episode created by P. Vajrappa and Kalloor Shrinivas.

Design & Direction: Dr. M. Ganesha

Music: Arunkumar M.

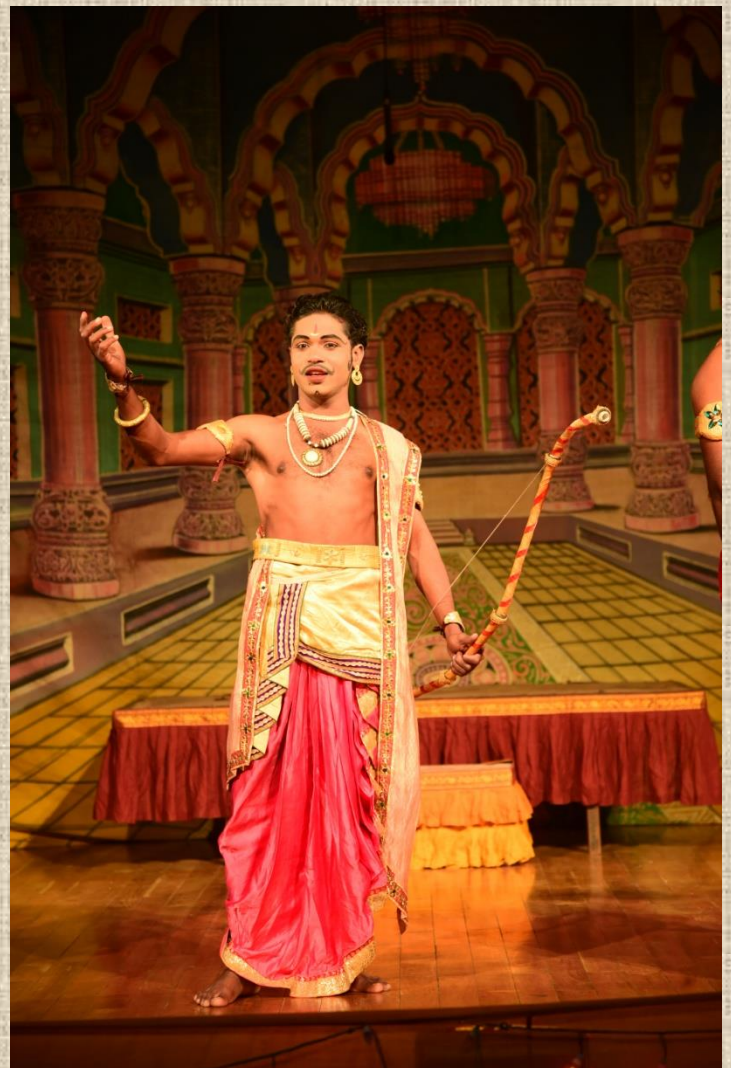
SYNOPSIS:

The production covers the series of events in the Mahabharata beginning with Krishna's embarking on a peace mission to Duryodhana and the failure of the mission; the insults that Krishna suffers at the Kauravas Court; the discussions and debates that take place within the Pandava and the Kaurava families themselves; Draupadi's expression of an unquenchable wrath and demand for avenging her humiliation, and culminating in the great war. The events all throw light on ideas of dharma and adharma, peace and violence, revenge and reconciliation, personal preferences and collective duties, the virtues and weaknesses of human beings in general. Conceived and staged in the Company natak format, the production uses stylised acting and dialogue rendition, songs and musical accompaniment, elaborate sets and costumes.

Director's Note :



In my native place Timmappana halli and in surrounding village, I enjoyed watching enactment of Kurukshethra, Ramayana, Danashuraveerakarna, Rajavikarama etc. that were performed annually when I came to Bangalore for my higher studies, my ties with company theater were left behind. When I look back and think about how I left then, watching company theater, I feel amused. I wouldn't miss even the all-night rehearsals of these plays. As I was a kid I wouldn't get any opportunities to act but no one could withhold my opportunity to watch those plays. Saturdays and Sundays being holidays, it was my turn to look after the cattle. I used to rehearse these stories with my fellow cattle men. The mud from the wells that were being dug was our "Aharya" (make - up), the bamboo sticks were our bows and arrows, Worn out plastic picture the weapon (gada), the surrounding lakes become rivers and seas, The greenery was a dense forest, we the characters of *Ramayana* and *Mahabharatha*. I had never thought that the games, which we played as kids. Would become the texts for my future studies. Ninasam has thought me these playful games in our theater course. But with discipline. In the year 2014-15 Ninasam trained student with different texts of *Kurukshethra*. Though the group was of young students, their singing and acting was of professional level. The nearby villagers come in crowds to watch this play. I had thought of doing this play much earlier for Janamanadata. But it couldn't be possible for many reasons. Now, the actor Manju Sirigere, Nagaraja Sirsi, Sharath S Mysore, Uma Y.G Kolara, Shrinivasamurthy Tumakuru, along with help of other actors and technicians, came together to recreate this play for Janamanadata.



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MEMBERS OF THE JANAMANADATA TROUPE 2019-20.

Director/s: Dr. M. Ganesha.

Actors: Y Manjunath, Nagaraj Sirsi, Uma Y G, Halebasappa, Manjappa Huligi, Shivaraja, Vani Reddy, Poornima, Sathish Chauhan, Basavaraj, Kriyappa Kavaluru, Peerappa H Doddamani, Naveen Prathap, Rajath, Shruthi V, Mahantesh, Durga,

Technical Help: Manju Kodagu, Arun Kumar M, Dingri Naresh, Shrinivasamurthy, Sundaresh, Y Manjunath, Vidya Shivamogga, Ranganath, Shrikanth, Sujatha, Sriharsha Gobhat, Phaniyamma.

Music: Arun Kumar M.

Music Operation: Ravikumar Benni, Bharath Dingri, Raghava Kammar, Basavaraj.

Lighting: Satish Chauhan.

Dr. M. Ganesha : Dr. M. Ganesha did his Masters in Kannada from Bangalore University. He completed theatre training at Ninasam Theater Institute, Heggodu and then got appointed as a faculty at Ninasam. He received Doctorate from Kuvempu University for his thesis on *Kannada Rangabhoomiya Hosa Sadhyathegalu* (New possibilities in Kannada theatre). An actor, director and organizer, he has worked in many theatre troupes including Ninasam Tirugata, Charaka, Kinnaramela, Protheo, Spandana, Kagodu Rangamancha, Navu Mandya. the central *Sangeet Natak Academi* has Awarded him *Bismillah Khan Yuva Puraskar-2007*. He was also awarded the *Best Actor* award for the movie *Dhali* in *Bellimandala and Ambegalu film festival*. He worked as a director of Rangayana, Shivamogga between June -2017 to Sep-2019. Currently he is working as the Principal of Ninasam Theater Intitute, Heggodu.



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JANAMANADATA SHOWS SCHEDULE

2019-20

Date	Shows	Place
01-04-2019	KURKSHETHRA	K.H. Kalasouda, Bangalore
02-04-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Malavalli
03-04-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Avarthi
04-04-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Putturu
05-04-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Mangalore
06-04-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Tumari
07-04-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Yadiyala
08-04-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Hampi
09-04-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Hosapet
13-04-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Sirigeri
14-04-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Channagiri
16-04-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Banavasi
17-04-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Hanagal
30-04-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Basavakalyana
03-05-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Sirsi
04-05-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Tumakuru
05-05-2019	KURKSHETHRA	ADA –Bangalore
06-05-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Barur
07-05-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Huvinahadagali
08-05-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Bailahongala
09-05-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Hanagal
10-05-2019	KURKSHETHRA	Bellary

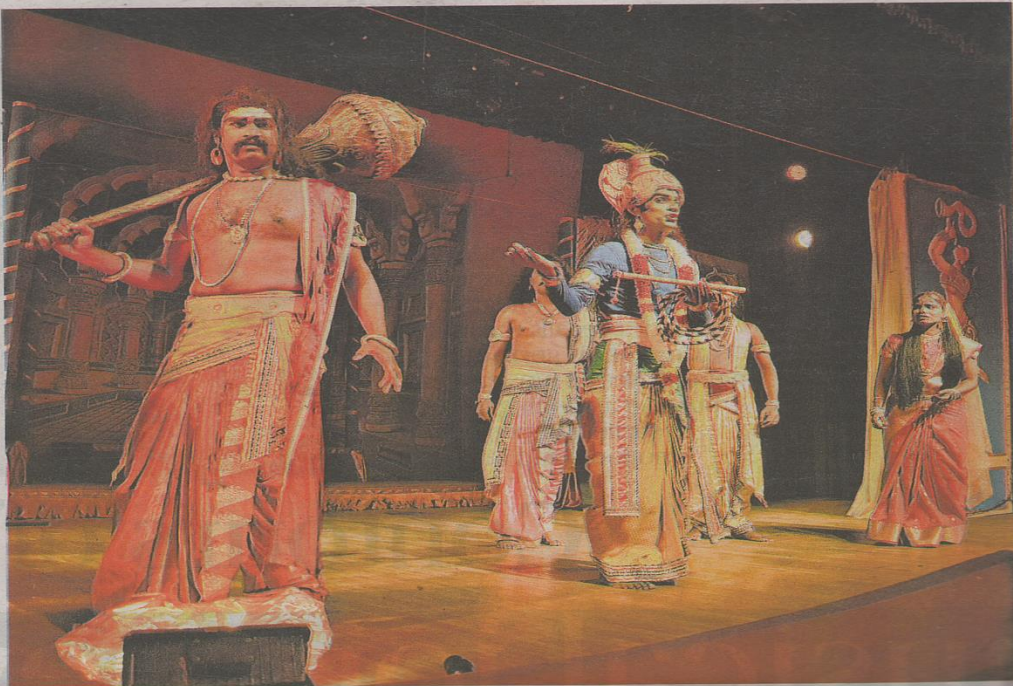


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RESPONSE:

Most of the performances were followed by discussions with the audience, local organisers and media, and special invitees. These made for lively and rewarding sessions, which consisted of feedback, critical observations, questions, seeking of clarifications from the audience, and a general summing up by expert moderators. The production received high acclaim from all sections. Patrons communicated their appreciation orally, formally as well as informally, through letters and reviews published in various periodicals and newspapers, and through comments on social media platforms like facebook. Enclosed here are some reports/reviews of the production from a couple of years ago when Kurukshetra was making waves even after two years of its premiering.

Conjuring up
good old
days A scene
from
Kurukshetra



MANGALURU FRIDAYREVIEW
FRIDAY, MAY 4, 2018

Company drama in contemporary times

A bunch of youngsters bring to stage B. Puttaswamayya's play, Kurukshetra. Directed by M. Ganesh, presently the director of Rangayana, Shimoga, the play attempts to revive the magic of good old times

MANASA KAMBANNA

"Making arrows from bamboo sticks, smearing mud all over the body and wearing fowl feathers, me and my shepherd friends used to recreate the breath-taking drama scenes that we had watched the previous night.

I grew up watching drama company plays and everything about them had created a fascination in me," recalls Dr. M. Ganesh, who taught theatre at Ninasam, and presently Director, Rangayana Shimoga. All night plays based on Ramayana, Mahabharata and other puranas were common in most villages during summer when agricultural activities would take a halt. Setting up of the stage itself, he says, brought a magical world into the rural space and the whole practice was to amuse villagers who were exhausted from a yearlong labour.

Kurukshetra, a play direct-

ed by Ganesh is being staged all over the State: it takes its inspiration from company plays. The whole village would come alive with total participation. With this culture slowly fading away, "my childhood memories impelled me to reinvigorate, staging it in not only villages, but also in urban and semi-urban areas," says Ganesh, who has trained amateurs of Sathyashodhana Ranga Samudaya every night for a whole month.

This plot of Kurukshetra has over the years taken various forms with each troupe improvising it by altering the dialogues, scenes and songs. One of the versions of the play was called *Sri Krishna Sandhaana*, made famous by Gubbi Company. "We kept all those versions in mind while drafting the play and selected the aspects that would add value to our version."

The group based the play majorly on B. Puttaswamayya's *Kurukshetra* and took the

essence of *Smashana Kurukshetra* by Kuvempu where Krishna unravels the truth of existence to Duryodhana during his death. "We are also grateful to theatre masters P. Vajrappa and Kalloru Srinivasa as we adapted a lot from their models as well," he

The plot of Kurukshetra has over the years taken various forms with each troupe improvising it adds.

This Kurukshetra, he explains, is a family drama which involves fights between cousins, the Pandavas and the Kauravas, helplessness of Karna, the first son of Kunti, grudge of Duryodhana against his rivals and the agony of Gandhari who is placed in a difficult situation where she cannot stop her son from resorting to war. To replicate

the old style of presentation, "the actors themselves sing and the whole play is a musical treat."

The troupe has incurred an expenditure of four lakhs for this production. "The sharing of profits equally among all the actors and technicians without any regard to the role or seniority is what makes the troupe special," he mentions.

The intention of this new play is "to recreate the purpose and glory of folk style. In providing a taste of rural drama, we hope the style and technique of this form would survive," says Ganesh.

The troupe has rendered 20 shows at various places including Thirthahalli, Mandya, Puttur, Mysore, Kunigal and Sirsa.

It will be staged in Bangalore at Rangashankara on May 5, 7.30 p.m. Tickets are priced at Rs. 150 and can be bought at the venue or booked online on www.bookmyshow.com.



drashekar (middle)

ACHIEVEMENTS:

The following point to the output and achievements of Janamanadata:

- Janamanadata, a theatre repertory, has been working continuously from 2005, producing plays on a regular basis every since then.
- It has travelled over most parts of Karnataka every year and even outside its boundaries on some occasions.
- An average of 500 people have watched each Janamanadata show every year between 2005-19.
- Special mention can be made of Mandya district, where alone immense public demand made us stage 15 shows. About 1,500 people used to gather for each show of Kurukshethra, sometimes putting up their own sets and properties and requesting us to perform using them.
- The project has worked with highly regarded directors from inside as also outside Karnataka.
- Proper accounts and documents have been maintained all through the years of the project.
- Detailed documentation of the project activities is being done through photographs, slides, videos, and news clippings and reviews.

The project has been lauded for the professional quality as well as the artistic merit of its works, which according to many is easily comparable to those of any major theatre troupe or project in India.



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